



Inspiring win: The White Ferns had endured a 10-match losing streak before the T20 World Cup. But they've now claimed their first-ever T20 title, ending a wait that included back-to-back final losses in 2009 and 2010. REUTERS

believable 297 for six against Bangladesh in Hyderabad. The architect of that mammoth score, Sanju Samson, would go on to slam two more T20I hundreds in the four-match series against South Africa to finally cement his spot in

the team. Samson, Tilak Varma, who also struck twin hundreds on that tour, and opener Abhishek Sharma emerged as the leaders of the newfangled Indian T20I batting set-up.

The wheels for this charge of the young brigade were set in motion during an unprecedented Indian Premier League (IPL) season, which saw the average run rate soar to 9.56 in 2024 from 8.99 in 2023. The Impact Player rule, instituted in 2023, saw teams aim for the stratosphere as eight of the league's top 10 highest team totals were registered

in 2024, altering the lexicon of the format and reducing bowlers to hapless bystanders.

This was, however, in stark contrast to the T20 World Cup that followed.

With a large part of the tournament being held on sluggish drop-in pitches in the USA, the average run-scoring plummeted to 7.09 per six balls — the lowest ever run rate for a single edition in the competition's history. Thus, cricket's American experiment was a far cry from the star-spangled spectacle it was billed to be.